

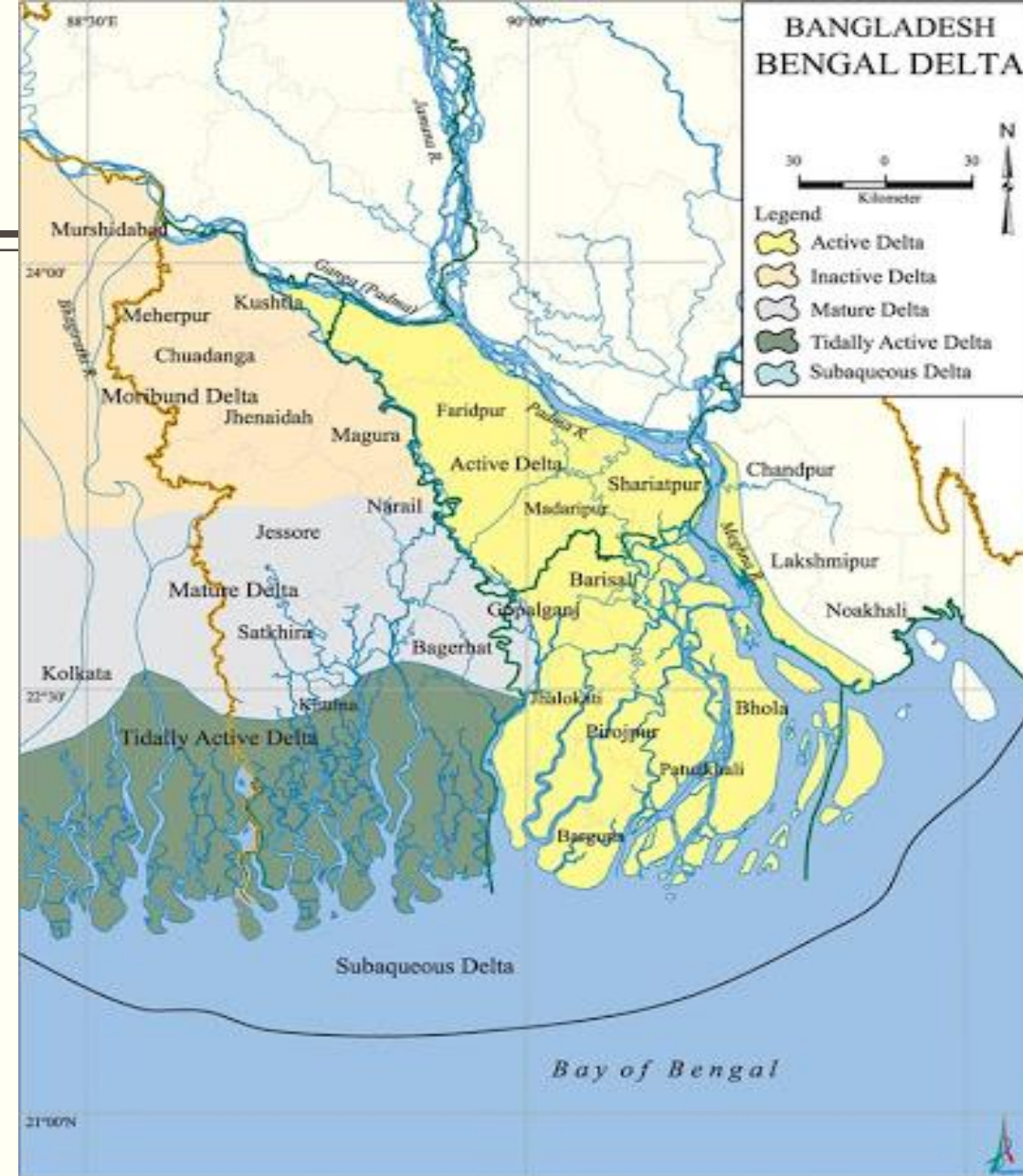
L4. SOCIO- POLITICAL PROFILE OF RULERS OF BENGAL

Ancient Period



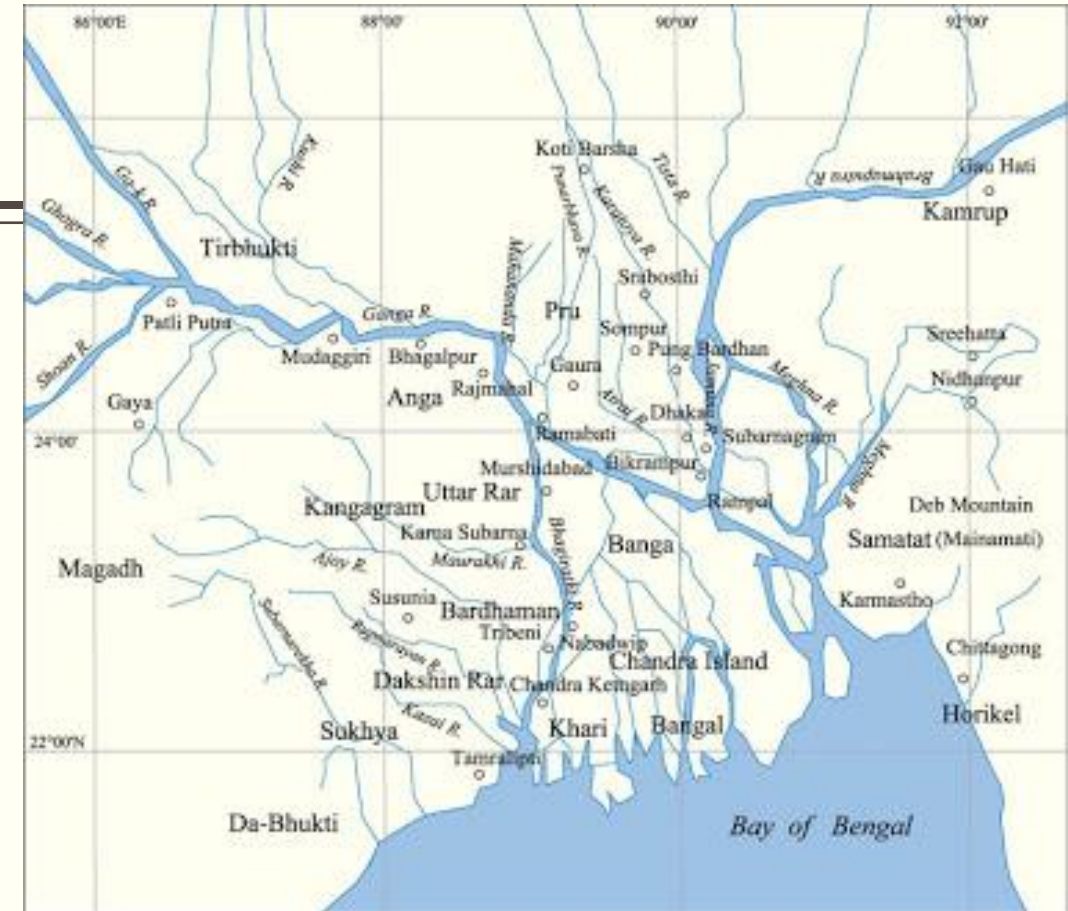
Foundation period 50,000 – 13th century +

- Period of continuous migration till agriculture settled. Migration of different population groups
- Mongoloids dominated from South East Asian zone – Wet zone attracted by deltaic food availability potential
- Economics – From non-settled and shifting cultivation to settled agriculture
- Society was forming at a very nascent stage. No organized state system. Some 'superimposed' advanced habitation possible but scant reference.

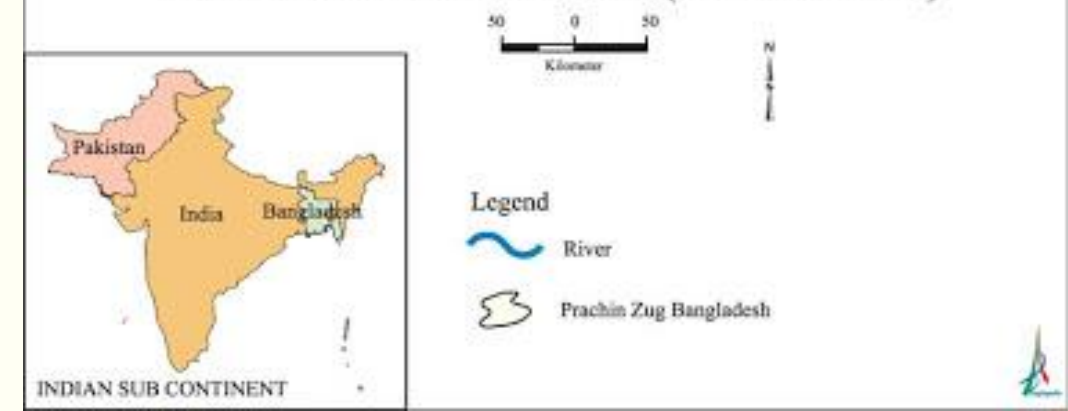


Ancient Janapadas

- From the Vedic literature, we know that non-Aryan people used to live in the janapadas like Vanga, pundra, radha and gauda.
- Samatata was an important janapada located in (Comilla-Noakhali area).
- The Chittagong with its neighboring areas was known by the name of Harikela.



HISTORY OF BANGLADESH (ANCIENT ERA)



Aryanisation

- Aryan influence was felt in the north in the second millennium BC
- Bengal experienced the Aryanisation quite late
- The pre-Aryan culture of people of Bengal got enough time to become deeply rooted.
- Prehistoric stone tools have been discovered in various parts of West Bengal in the districts of Midnapur, Bankura and Burdwan.
- The original settlers were the non-Aryan ethnic groups- Austric or Austro-Asiatics. Peoples of two other ethnic groups settled in Bengal and their languages were Dravidian and Tibeto-Burman.

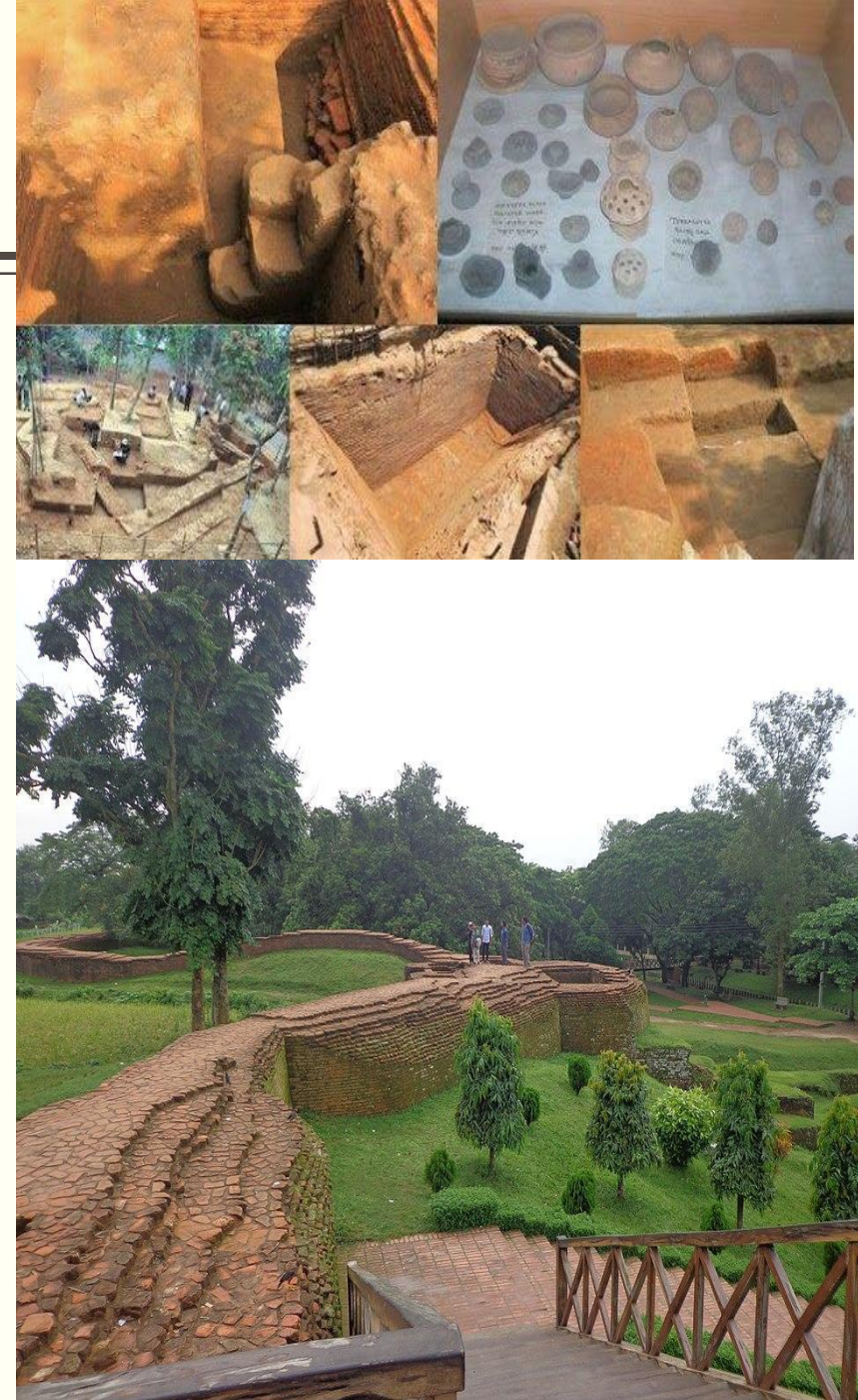


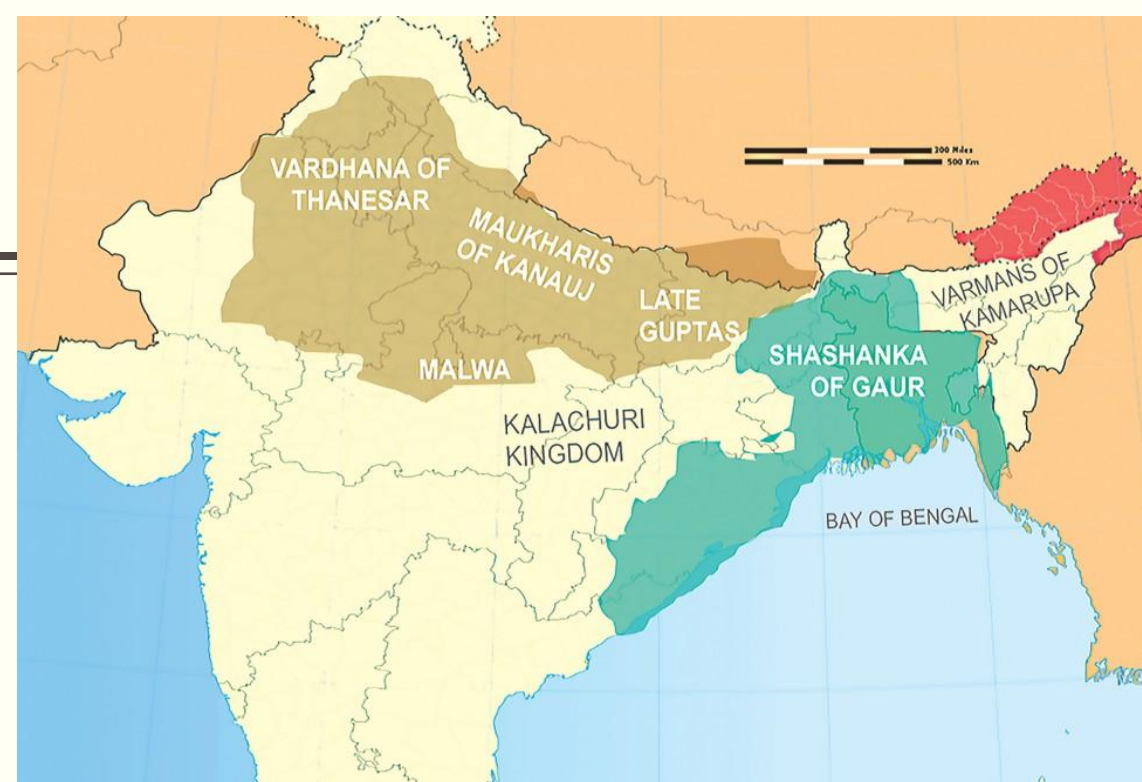
Image: Remnants of the city wall in Mahasthangar, one of the oldest urban settlements in Bengal

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Shashank

- By the beginning of the seventh century Shashank captured power in Gauda.
- First important king of Bengal, who introduced Bengal for the first time in her history as power that attempted to establish supremacy over northern India.
- Shashanka's capital was at Karnasuvarna (near Rajshahi)



Pala Dynasty

- After death of Shasanka, for a century there was little political stability in Bengal, was insecure because of internal conflict and invasions from outside. Bengal was a state of Matsyanyayam.
- Gopala, the founder of the Pala dynasty
- In the period of Pala dominance Bengal saw the dynamic rule of Dharmapala and Devapala. Palas were powerful enough to take an attempt for the control of northern India. They were involved in a **tripartite struggle** with the Gurjara Pratiharas of western India and the Rastrakutas of southern India.
- Dharmapala founded the vikramasila mahabihar and somapura mahabihar at Paharpur, these are monumental architectural works of Dharmapala.
- Vijayasena, a feudal lord in the Pala empire, found opportunity to gather strength. By the 12th century AD the Palas were overthrown. Vijayasena's ancestors came from the Karnata which is in southern India.



Image: Somapura Mahavihara a World Heritage Site was built by Dharmapala, Coin of the Pala Empire, Mahipala I and later. Circa 988-1161 CE

Southeastern Bengal

- In the 7th century AD when the Later Guptas captured power in Gauda, the southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the **Khadga kings**.
- Southeastern Bengal emerged as a kingdom of significant size and strength under **the Deva dynasty** in the 8th century AD and their capital was at Devaparvata which a city in the Mainamati-Lalmai area.
- In the 9th century AD southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the kingdom of Harikela. **The Chandras** became the Harikela rulers. Their capital was Vikramapura. At the eleventh century AD the Varman Dynasty, established their independent rule in southeastern Bengal. The Varmanas were overthrown by the Senas. The Varmanas were Hindus and their capital was at Vikramapura.
- **The rulers of southeastern Bengal commanded the sea trade.**

Image: The archaeological site of Mainamati, Comilla was a religious center used by the Chandra dynasty



Sena Dynasty

- Vijayasena was successful in bringing the whole Bengal under one unified rule which continued up to 1204 AD.
- Vikramapura, which was the capital of the Chandras and the Varmans, continued to be the capital of the Senas as well.
- The Sena rulers were Hindus and their rule is considered to be a period of revival of Hinduism. They tried to bring back Hindu belief in Bengal society which has for a long time had maintained religious toleration and Hindu-Buddhist peace.



Image: excavation site of the ancient city of Vikrampur, a major Buddhist center that was the capital at one time or another of the Chandra (900-1050), Varman (1080-1150) and Sena (1100-1230) dynasties. *Munshiganj district, Bangladesh*

